

FORMULA 1

2026 SEASON

Understanding the Broadcast Graphics

A Beginner's Guide to Formula 1

Understanding the Broadcast

Making Sense of F1's On-Screen Graphics

Formula 1's live broadcast uses a rich set of on-screen graphics to convey race information in real time. Understanding these graphics transforms the viewing experience from passive watching to informed analysis.

2026 Broadcast Note

Apple TV+ becomes a major broadcast partner for F1 starting in 2026, bringing updated graphics packages and presentation styles. Core information elements remain consistent, though visual design may evolve throughout the season.

The Timing Tower

The timing tower is the vertical leaderboard displayed on the left side of the screen. It is the single most important graphic for following the race.

Element	Description	Example
Position	Current race position	1, 2, 3...
Driver Code	Three-letter abbreviation	VER, HAM, NOR
Team Color	Colored bar showing team identity	Red Bull = dark blue
Interval	Gap to car directly ahead	+1.234
Gap to Leader	Total gap to the race leader	+12.567
Pit Indicator	Shows when a driver is in the pits	PIT / OUT
Tire Compound	Current tire compound and age	M (Lap 12)
Position Change	Arrow showing gained/lost positions	Up/Down arrow

Timing Tower Modes: The tower can switch between interval mode (gap to car ahead, most common), leader mode (gap to P1), practice/qualifying mode (lap times and sector splits), and pit stop mode (pit durations and positions gained/lost).

Sector Colors

Each circuit is divided into three sectors (S1, S2, S3). As a driver completes each sector, the time is color-coded to show performance.

Color	Meaning	Detail
PURPLE	Overall fastest	Fastest sector time by ANY driver in the session
GREEN	Personal best	Driver's own best sector time in the session
YELLOW	Not a personal best	Slower than the driver's previous best
WHITE	First timed lap	No comparison available yet

Reading Sectors in Qualifying

Watch the sector colors to predict lap times before the driver crosses the line. Three purple sectors = potential pole lap. A yellow sector means the driver has lost time and the lap may not improve their position.

Tire Information

Understanding Pirelli's Color-Coded Compounds

Dry Compounds

Compound	Color	Range	Characteristics
Hard	WHITE	C1-C2	Most durable, least grip, longest stints
Medium	YELLOW	C2-C4	Balanced durability and performance
Soft	RED	C3-C5	Maximum grip, fastest degradation, qualifying

Wet Compounds

Compound	Color	Usage
Intermediate	GREEN	Damp/drying track; light rain or drying conditions
Full Wet	BLUE	Heavy rain; standing water on track

Compound Selection

Pirelli selects three of the five dry compounds (C1-C5) for each Grand Prix. These are labeled Hard, Medium, and Soft regardless of which C-numbers they actually are. A C3 tire might be the 'Hard' at one race and the 'Soft' at another.

Telemetry & Data Overlays

Speed & Gear

Speed (km/h or mph) displayed as a large number on onboard views. Gear indicator shows current gear (1-8), often with RPM bar. Speed trace compares two drivers through a lap. Speed trap shows maximum speed recorded at a specific point.

Throttle & Brake

Throttle application bar (0-100%), brake pressure bar (often red-colored), and combined view for comparing driving styles into braking zones.

ERS & Battery (New for 2026)

~50% Electric Power	350 kW MGU-K	0 MGU-H (Removed)
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- Battery state of charge: Percentage or bar showing remaining energy
- ERS deployment: Visual indicator of when electric power is being used
- ERS harvesting: Shows when MGU-K is recovering energy under braking
- X-Mode indicator: Shows when active aero is in low-drag configuration
- Power split graphic: Pie chart or bar showing ICE vs. electric power

Why ERS Matters More in 2026

With ~50% of power from electric sources, battery management becomes as important as tire strategy. Drivers who manage energy better will have a significant advantage. Watch the battery graphic to see who is deploying and harvesting efficiently.

Flags & Their Meanings

Primary Means of Communication with Drivers

Flag	Color/Pattern	Meaning
Green	Solid green	Track clear, racing conditions, session start
Yellow	Solid yellow	Danger ahead, slow down, no overtaking in zone
Double Yellow	Two yellow flags	Great danger, be prepared to stop
Red	Solid red	Session stopped, return to pit lane immediately
Blue	Solid blue	Let faster car through (lapped traffic)
White	Solid white	Slow-moving vehicle ahead
Black	Solid black	Driver disqualified (shown with car number)
Black/Orange	Black + orange circle	Car has mechanical issue, must pit
Black/White	Diagonal halves	Unsportsmanlike behavior warning
Yellow/Red	Red + yellow stripes	Slippery surface (oil, water, debris)
Checkered	Black/white checks	Session or race finished

Safety Car (SC): Yellow 'SC' banner across timing tower; field bunches up. **VSC:** 'VSC' indicator; cars maintain delta time. **SC ending:** 'SC IN THIS LAP' message before green flag restart.

Weather Graphics

Metric	What It Shows	Why It Matters
Air Temp	Ambient air temperature	Affects engine cooling and aero
Track Temp	Road surface temperature	Major impact on tire grip/degradation
Humidity	Moisture in the air (%)	Affects engine performance
Wind Speed	Wind velocity and direction	Impacts aero balance on straights
Rain Probability	Chance of rain (%)	Triggers strategy decisions
Radar	Rain radar overlay of circuit	Shows approaching weather systems

Additional Broadcast Elements

Battle Graphics

Head-to-head comparison between close drivers, gap timer showing live interval, overtake probability (experimental AI-driven graphic), and historical lap comparison.

Strategy Graphics

Pit stop window predictions, undercut/overcut analysis, tire life remaining estimates, and race progression charts (lap-by-lap position chart for all drivers).

Driver Communications

Team radio transcripts displayed on screen, Driver-of-the-Day voting graphics, penalty notifications with explanation, and track limit warnings.

Quick Reference Card

Print This Page as a Race Day Cheat Sheet

Sector Colors at a Glance

PURPLE	GREEN	YELLOW
Session Fastest	Personal Best	Not Improved

Tire Colors at a Glance

Soft (Red)	Medium (Yellow)	Hard (White)	Inter (Green)	Wet (Blue)
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Common Flag Summary

Green	Yellow	Red	Blue	Checkered
Clear	Danger	Stopped	Move over	Finished

Points (Race / Sprint)

	1st	2nd	3rd	4th	5th	6th	7th	8th	9th	10th
Race/Sprint	25/8	18/7	15/6	12/5	10/4	8/3	6/2	4/1	2/-	1/-

+1 point for fastest lap in the Grand Prix (if finishing in top 10).